

Rococo

Emerging from the gilded splendour of the Palace of Versailles (1623–82), the rococo developed as a lavish, decorative style in contrast with the baroque preceding it. The name derives from the French word *rocaille*, which described the shell-covered rock-work used to decorate artificial grottoes, and *coquille*, meaning seashell. Rococo architecture is light-hearted and frivolous, with abundant curves, scrolls, gilding, elements of fantasy and ornament. Where the drama of the baroque emphasized balance and stability, rococo was graceful and fluid, and accentuated asymmetry. Outstanding examples include the Catherine Palace in St Petersburg (1717–23), designed by Johann-Friedrich Braunstein, the Queluz National Palace in Portugal (1747–92), designed by Mateus Vicente de Oliveira (1706–86), and the Chinese House in Potsdam, Germany (1738), designed by Emmanuel Héré de Corny (1705–63). Other notable rococo architects include Francesco Bartolomeo Rastrelli (1700–71), Philip de Lange (c.1705–66) and Matthäus Daniel Pöppelmann (1662–1736).



Church of Saint Francis of Assisi, Ouro Preto, Brazil, 1766